Australia Day: A Celebration or a Day of Mourning?

Target Audience: B1+ / B2 (Upper-Intermediate)
Time: 45-50 minutes
Approach: CLIL + Socio-cultural approach
Lesson Objectives:

- Educational (Content): Understand the historical context of Australia Day (January 26, 1788) and the reasons why it is a controversial date for Indigenous Australians (including the 1938 Day of Mourning).
- Linguistic (Language): Practice vocabulary related to history and social justice (e.g., *invasion, mourning, controversial, treaty, resolution*), and develop reading and debating skills.
- Socio-cultural: Develop critical thinking and empathy by analyzing two opposing cultural perspectives on the same historical event and comparing them with the students' own national holidays (Dialogue of Cultures).

Stage	Stage aim	Timing	Procedure	Aids and materials
Warm-up	Activate background knowledge and introduce the core conflict.	5 min	Teacher shows two pictures: 1) A beach party with Australian flags. 2) A protest with Aboriginal flags. Ask: *"Look at these two photos. They are from the same day in Australia (January 26). Why are some people celebrating and others protesting?"*	Pictures of Australia Day celebration and Invasion Day protest.
Controlled Practice	Pre-teach vocabulary needed for reading and debate.	7 min	Vocabulary Match. Students match words: *invasion, mourning, controversial, treaty, resolution*. Look at the title. What do you think the two opinions will say?	Vocabulary Match, presentation slide
Reading	Develop reading skills for detailed understanding of	10 min	Students read the extended text . They complete the comparison	Text and Table https://blogs.loc.gov/law/2017/01

	two cultural perspectives.		table.	/australias-national-day/ , Invasion Day rallies, new citizens and barbecues: Australia Day marked across the country , The evolution of Australia Day controversy
Post-Reading	Develop critical thinking and check understanding of historical facts.	5 min	Teacher asks questions based on the text: *"What happened in 1788? What happened in 1938? What percentage of the Indigenous population was lost?"*	Board
Freer Practice	Apply knowledge, develop speaking skills through the "Dialogue of Cultures"	15 min	Formal Debate. Divide into two teams: Team A (Change the Date) and Team B (Keep the Date). Students must use the historical facts (1788, 1938, 90% loss) as arguments. Structure: 3 min preparation → 2 min opening statements → 5 min open discussion → 2 min closing statements.	Debate structure and useful phrases)
Homework and feedback	Summarize and reflect.	5 min	*"Can a country celebrate its national day if it hurts a part of its population?"* Homework: Write a short paragraph (50 words): *"Should countries change national holidays if they are painful for minority groups? Why or why not?"*	Notebooks

Match the words (1-5) with their definitions (A-E).

Word	Letter	Definition
1. Invasion	[ ]	A. A formal agreement between two groups (often about peace or land).
2. Mourning	[ ]	B. The act of entering a country or region with an army to take control of it.
3. Controversial	[ ]	C. Causing a lot of disagreement or argument.
4. Treaty	[ ]	D. The expression of deep sadness for someone who has died or for a tragic event.
5. Resolution	[ ]	E. A formal statement of opinion or decision voted on by a group of people.

1. B
2. D
3. C
4. A
5. E

Australia Day: Two Perspectives

Perspective 1: "It's a Day to Celebrate" (by Mark, Sydney)
Australia Day is our national day. It is a time for barbecue, beach, and family. On January 26, we celebrate how far our country has come. We are a peaceful, multicultural, and successful nation. It is a day to celebrate our freedom and our democracy.

The date marks the arrival of the First Fleet in 1788, when Captain Arthur Phillip raised the British flag at Sydney Cove . For many Australians, this is the beginning of modern Australia. Yes, the past had difficult moments, but we cannot change history. We respect the First Nations people, but we also need a day to celebrate our national

identity. Changing the date won't fix the past. We should focus on the future and celebrate together.

Perspective 2: "It's a Day of Mourning" (by Tanya, Aboriginal activist)
For my people, January 26 is not a day to celebrate. It is the anniversary of the invasion. In 1788, the British arrived, and our lives changed forever. We lost our land, our culture, and many of our people. Between 1788 and 1900, the Indigenous population of Australia was reduced by as much as 90% due to new diseases and violent treatment .

That is why we call it "Invasion Day" or a "Day of Mourning". This is not a new idea. As early as 1938, Aboriginal leaders met in Sydney and passed a resolution protesting the mistreatment of Aboriginal people since 1788 . Today, thousands of Australians still gather for "Invasion Day" rallies every year . We cannot celebrate on a day that marks so much pain. We don't want to destroy the celebration—we just want a date that includes everyone. A date that is not painful for the First Nations people.

Read both texts and complete the table.

	Perspective 1 (Celebrate)	**Perspective 2 (Mourn)**
What is January 26?	1. _____	2. _____
Key historical facts mentioned	3. _____	4. _____
What is their solution?	5. _____	6. _____

1. A day to celebrate the country (the beginning of modern Australia in 1788).
2. The anniversary of the invasion (1788) and the loss of land.
3. The First Fleet arrived in 1788; Captain Arthur Phillip raised the flag; modern Australia began.

4. Between 1788 and 1900, the Indigenous population was reduced by 90%; Aboriginal leaders protested in 1938.
5. Keep the date and celebrate together.
6. Change the date to something that includes everyone.

Motion: *"Australia Day should be moved to a different date."*

Team A: Change the Date (Affirmative)

- Argument 1: January 26 is a painful date for Indigenous people (it marks the invasion and the 90% population loss).
- Argument 2: A national day should unite everyone, not divide people.
- Argument 3: Changing the date is a simple way to show respect to First Nations people (who protested as early as 1938).

Team B: Keep the Date (Negative)

- Argument 1: Changing the date won't fix the past. We need to focus on the future.
- Argument 2: The date is not about 1788; it's about celebrating modern Australia.
- Argument 3: Changing the date divides the country even more and is just "political correctness".

Useful Phrases for Debate:

- Opening: *"We strongly believe that..."*
- Using facts: *"According to the text, in 1788..."*
- Rebuttal: *"I understand your point, but I have to disagree because..."*
- Closing: *"To sum up, our position is the most reasonable because..."*